Peter Goes Back to School

The gospel of grace governs not only how a person is saved but how believers live together — and even a Spirit-taught apostle can drift under social pressure, needing loving but public correction anchored in justification by faith alone.

Where this study fits

Galatians · sixteen studies · this study highlighted

01 1:1–5 The Ground of Liberty	**02** 1:6–10 The One True Gospel	**03** 1:11–17 Paul's Independent Revelation	**04** 1:18–2:10 Paul's Gospel Is Independent of the Judean Churches
05 2:11–21 Peter Goes Back to School	**06** 3:1–5 Under a Spell	**07** 3:6–14 Blessing or a Curse	**08** 3:15–29 The Superiority of the Promise to the Law
09 4:1–11 When I Became a Man	**10** 4:12–20 A Steel Fist in a Velvet Glove	**11** 4:21–31 Paul's Old Testament Story	**12** 5:1–12 Taking a Stand in Liberty
13 5:13–26 Walk in the Spirit	**14** 6:1–5 Brothers and Burdens	**15** 6:6–10 Sowing and Reaping	**16** 6:11–18 Teaching the Truth

Four marks of the confrontation

Galatians 2:11–14 · Outline I — Paul confronts Peter about the gospel

A **Public · v.11**

ἀντέστην
“I withstood him to his face” — and “before them all” (v.14)

B **Pointed · v.12**

ὑπέστελλεν
Ate with Gentiles — then withdrew when men came from James

C **Poisonous · v.13**

συνυπεκρίθησαν
The rest of the Jews joined in — “even Barnabas was carried away”

D **Practical · v.14**

ὀρθοποδοῦσιν
Not “straight-footed” about the truth of the gospel

“If you, being a Jew, live in the manner of Gentiles and not as the Jews, why do you compel Gentiles to live as Jews?” (v.14)

Peter knew better

Galatians 2:11 · Outline I.A.1–3

1

Prepared better — Acts 10
The sheet from heaven: “What God has cleansed you must not call common.” He then went to Cornelius.

about A.D. 40
taught by revelation

2

Preached better — Acts 11:17
“Who was I that I could withstand God?” — he defended eating with Gentiles before the Jerusalem leaders.

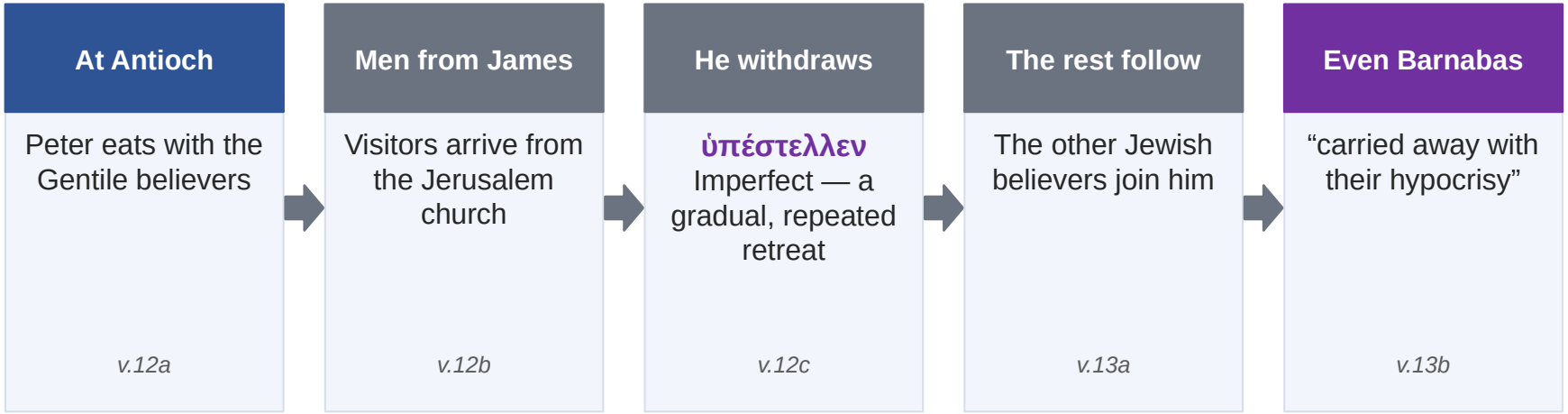
3

Promised better — Galatians 2:9
James, Peter and John gave Paul the right hand of fellowship: you go to the Gentiles.

“He was to be blamed” — κατεγνωσμένος, Perf. Pass. Ptc.: his conduct stood condemned, not his standing before God.

How the drift happened

Galatians 2:12–13 · Outline I.B–C



The example said there were two bodies of Christ — one Jewish, one Gentile. Hypocrisy spreads in community.

Separate by birth — the same by faith

Galatians 2:15–16 · Outline II — Paul corrects Peter

Separate — v.15
φύσει by nature, by birth

- “We who are Jews by nature, and not sinners of the Gentiles”
- Born Jews, not proselytes (Phil 3:4–5)
- A distinction Paul grants only to dissolve it

The same — v.16
δικαιόω to declare righteous · forensic

× **not by the works of the law**
three times in one verse

✓ **by faith in Jesus Christ**
three times in one verse

Any man, Jew or Gentile — a legal declaration received by faith

Six times in one verse: not by the law — but by faith. Justification is declared, not earned.

Paul's argument with Peter

Galatians 2:17–21 · Outline III

vv.17–18	Peter's error — rebuilding what he destroyed makes him the transgressor	**παραβάτης** one who oversteps a line
v.19	“Through the law I died to the law that I might live to God”	**ζήσω** dying to the law opens a new life
v.20a	Dead — “I have been crucified with Christ”	**συνεσταύρωμαι** Perf. — done, with lasting effect
v.20b	Alive — “Christ lives in me … I live by faith in the Son of God”	sanctification is by faith, too
v.21	“If righteousness comes through the law, then Christ died in vain”	**ἀθετῶ** “I do not set aside” — nullify

Discuss and apply

Galatians 2:11–21 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. Peter already knew the truth. What made him withdraw from the Gentiles anyway?

2. Why did Paul confront Peter publicly, “before them all,” rather than privately?

Apply

When Doing Right Costs You Socially

Name one place you've been managing others' opinions instead of living what you know is true — and take one visible step back toward it.

Resting in a Righteousness That Isn't Yours

Write down one way you've treated God's acceptance as conditional, then thank Him for the standing already yours in Christ.

In one line: Grace governs how we live together, not only how we are saved — knowing the truth must be matched by walking it.